park reassured Kashmir that they had made the right choice in joining secular India. That was a very powerful message that Rahul, the united Opposition and all the yatris sent to the people of Jammu–Kashmir and Ladakh—that we are all with you. That symbolic balm has helped assuage many a wounded heart, and they now look with hope to the Congress.

Rahul's emotional speech at the Sher-e-Kashmir cricket stadium changed something fundamentally in Kashmir's consciousness. It was warmly received and Kashmiris showered him with love. They felt that at long last someone had understood their travails and was sincerely listening to them and willing to redress their problems. Even as the snow fell, not a single person moved, some of them witnessing a snowfall for the first time. I also think that the foundations of the Opposition alliance were laid in Kashmir. Apart from Opposition leaders from Jammu and Kashmir, the Yatra hosted leaders from almost every corner of the nation. The Opposition genuinely felt as if they were collaborating on something bigger than individual partisan interests. I purposely mention this because it is easy to overlook the extremely hard and patient work of confidence-building. It is when such relationships are nurtured that leaders and parties are willing to make adjustments and accommodate each other.

My friend and colleague from the Prime Minister's Office wrote sometime back that Rahul Gandhi would be the next Prime Minister of India. Having talked and walked with him, I could say that lusting after power was the last thing on his mind. Like the story of Arjun and the championship, Rahul is committed to his goal of uniting India and reviving the Congress party. I pray he is successful. But I suspect that a day may come when the people of India themselves may want him as their Prime Minister. The boy who was his dadi's (grandmother's) favourite is well on his way to becoming the people's favourite. It is only a matter of time.

Sadly, the fantastic energy and process that the Yatra started has ground to a halt. Leaders and workers in the field have unfortunately not followed up on the inspiration of their young leader. Elections were won and lost, and the Congress party's organization sometimes ebbs and sometimes flows. As they say, time comes and goes, but it never returns. Presumably concerned